

# Oil/School: Land and Affiliation in the Age of Fossil Ed

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*ABSTRACT: This essay theorizes oil/school, an institutional formation in which public higher education is materially and rhetorically sustained by fossil fuel extraction. Focusing on universities in New Mexico, it examines the political contradictions embedded in a widely celebrated model of tuition-free higher education financed in part through oil and gas revenue. While such programs expand access for multiply marginalized college populations, they are simultaneously underwritten by extractive economies that shape the ecological and social environments prospective students inhabit. Through analyses of political discourse, extractive landscapes, and cultural narratives of land, the essay traces how petroleum wealth is mobilized to narrate educational opportunity while obscuring the environmental and social costs of extraction. In doing so, it offers oil/school as a framework for understanding how institutions of public higher education become entangled with extractive economies and the contested futures they produce.*

*KEYWORDS: fossil fuel extraction; higher education; land; oil/school; settler colonialism*

“. . . No land is empty. It must be made empty forcibly and ideologically”—K. Wayne Yang, “A ghetto land pedagogy: an antidote for settler environmentalism,” *Environmental Education Research*

“Proceed to the Route. Upon arrival, pick up loose, roadside threads. Use them to stitch shut the asking mouths.”—Toni Jensen, *Carry: A Memoir of Survival on Stolen Land*

## INTRODUCTION: HOMING STORIES

It was August 29, 2022. Driving north from New Mexico through the southern extension of the Rocky Mountains toward the Front Range in Colorado, I was thinking about an op-ed I’d read recently by Jonathan Juarez-Alonzo. Anyone who has traversed this route knows the feeling of being contoured by the land. In the face of the mountains, you’re molded into a new shape, rounded down. You lose your edges. The op-ed was titled, “Tuition-free college isn’t free when it’s funded by oil and gas” (Juarez-

Alonzo). With an oil and gas economy that pays for public funds allocated for social programs in the state, New Mexico owes the ebb and flow of its commitment to public higher education to the price of oil. This story would haunt me in a move across state borders. It asks something of me, now, as I find myself moving between teaching jobs at public universities in the Southwestern U.S.

Early last year, New Mexico Governor Michelle Lujan-Grisham signed Senate Bill 140, legislation known as the “Opportunity Scholarship,” making college tuition-free in New Mexico for resident graduates of any New Mexico high school (“Governor Signs”). On August 22nd, 2022, the ExxonMobil subsidiary XTO Permian Operating was fined \$1.7M for violating oil and gas wastewater disposal rules in New Mexico’s Permian Basin, where disposing wastewater from drilling has been under review because of its potential ties to regional earthquakes (Hedden). Despite sustained criticism from environmental advocates, New Mexico remains the second-largest oil-producing state in the country. Increasingly, the success of public higher education in the state is narrated alongside, and materially tied to, the success of the oil and gas industry, as political rhetoric grafts the promise of tuition-free college to the revenues of extraction. While tuition-free higher education is emerging as a compelling national policy narrative, in New Mexico narratives about its attainability remain deeply entangled with the ongoing expansion of fossil fuel production. In fact, all across the Southwestern U.S., oil—its extraction and profitability—is higher ed’s emerging local subtext.

I left my home in Albuquerque, New Mexico to teach in the Department of Women, Gender and Sexuality Studies at The University of Colorado, Boulder. I first grew up in Shiprock, New Mexico, near uranium and vanadium-ore processing facilities and milling operations that produced process-related wastes and radioactive tailings on the Navajo Nation. As a child, I later moved to Santa Fe, New Mexico, near Relief Route 599, a highway built for routine shipments of transuranic nuclear waste to bypass the

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wealthy state capital. According to V. Jo Hsu:

Homing stories situate individual experiences in relation to relevant histories and events, (re)composing [home] with the mutability of our growth and movements. This storytelling deliberately confronts systems of power and representation, paying particular attention to the author's relations and responsibilities (9).

My relationship to state- and federally-sanctioned programs of all kinds has been shaped by a settler upbringing, my “homing story”: attending school in Shiprock, on the Navajo Nation; moving to Santa Fe, the land of the settler story that never sleeps. Reflecting on the Opportunity Scholarship bill that was passed recently to support tuition-free higher education in New Mexico, I wish, urgently, to elaborate on how the bill resides in a tension around land, which is constructed in and through narrative. Whether New Mexico needs to make tuition accessible for all is not the central question. Rather, the question is how stories about land construct our relationships to place, shape our present and reveal the racialized logics through which settler colonialism is structured. The university must be called to account, through an attention to narrative and a new “homing story,” for the land politics its policies sustain and the futures they are imagined to defend.

## LAND

Driving north on I-25, desperate to hold onto a sense of belonging in my pursuit of teaching work near family and my community in Albuquerque, I told myself: *I-25 goes straight north on contiguous land. I'm not really leaving home.* I traversed the highway pass through the lower Rocky Mountains with my essential clothing, succulent plant, and my girlfriend's neck pillow and arrived at the University of Colorado Boulder, an institution established in 1876. Two cities in Colorado originally competed for the honor to host the University of Colorado: Cañon City and Boulder. The consolation prize for the losing city was to house the new Colorado State Prison. The land surrounding The University of Colorado, Boulder is contested by a number of interests and, in 2020, notably passed the strictest fracking regulations in the state of Colorado (Metzger). At the same time, Boulder County is consistently ranked one of the most expensive places to live in Colorado, with a median home value of \$736,000 in 2022. Most university faculty I meet at CU Boulder live a long commute from the campus and vie for housing in a real estate rental market characterized by “churn” and “tight inventory”

one hour away, in Denver. Real estate interests in maintaining the “pristine” landscapes surrounding Boulder County exemplify what K. Wayne Yang calls “settler environmentalism,” a framework that describes how environmental protection can operate within, and ultimately reinforce, settler colonial relations to land. As Yang explains, settler environmentalism draws on the logic of *terra sacer*, or sacred/accursed land, in which certain territories are framed simultaneously as desecrated spaces in need of rescue and as sacred wilderness worthy of preservation (115–30). Within this discourse, environmental protection becomes a mechanism through which settlers claim authority to manage, restore, and possess land, even as Indigenous histories of dispossession remain structurally unaddressed. The result, Yang argues, is a persistent narrative duality: “land as desecrated, in pain, in need of rescue; and land as sacred, wild, and preserve-able,” a framing that ultimately works to justify new forms of territorial control and “re-invasion” (117). In places like Boulder County, where strong anti-fracking and anti-drilling ordinances protect the surrounding foothills and open spaces, these environmental protections are also entangled with property regimes that concentrate access to protected landscapes among affluent residents. In this sense, environmental preservation can coexist with, and even intensify, forms of spatial exclusion, as only a narrow class of people can afford to live near lands safeguarded from extraction.

In terms of class-based environmental protections, Boulder, Colorado and Albuquerque, New Mexico, which houses the University of New Mexico’s flagship campus, provide a stark contrast. In 2018, the oil and gas industry identified the central Rio Grande Valley, or the Albuquerque Basin, as a potential site for horizontal drilling and hydraulic fracking. A report in the *Albuquerque Journal* that year, headlined, “Area’s drinking water is at risk from fracking,” illustrates the recurring tension between industry expansion and public safety: although a proposal for fracking had been rejected the previous year, another “industry-friendly extraction ordinance” was introduced to the county soon after (Craig). The debate over fracking in the Albuquerque Basin demonstrates whose voices and priorities dominate the governance of land and natural resources. Settler and industry interests often take precedence over Indigenous and local communities’ claims to water, land, and environmental health. In this context, the basin is simultaneously framed as a geologic formation, or a neutral depression of the Earth’s crust shaped by tectonic activity, and as a petroleum province, a resource-rich space to be exploited for commercial gain. These competing narratives reveal how settler environmentalism structures land governance, by legitimizing inter-

ventions by those with economic and political power while marginalizing histories of dispossession and environmental harm endured by Indigenous and other vulnerable communities. The article asks, “Can horizontal drilling and hydraulic fracking be done anywhere in the Albuquerque Basin without endangering our drinking water aquifer?” (Craig). In Albuquerque as in Boulder, one story of land captures the value and legacy of the areas adjacent to the cities, while another describes a region in which petroleum is found in commercial quantities, rendering the land a commercial prospect. Both of these stories describe the same place. Both of these stories persist.

There are many other places, and many other stories.

My students in Colorado pay a hefty sum to attend college, with tuition up more than 16% since 2012. For in-state undergraduate students, the tuition for the 2021-2022 academic year was \$12,995, discounting room and board. For out-of-state students, the tuition was \$39,900 per year (University of Colorado Boulder website). In 2021, tuition at the University of New Mexico was lower, but still \$6,836 and \$20,872, for in-state and out-of-state students, respectively (University of New Mexico website). The New Mexico Opportunity Scholarship Act with its promise of free tuition stands to change a lot for students graduating from a New Mexico high school. Indeed, by the fall of 2022, more than 11,000 students across all UNM campuses have participated in the scholarship, and cultural diversity in the most recent freshman class of students has reportedly increased, demonstrating a 29.8% increase in African American students, a 25.5% increase in Indigenous students, and a 16.1% increase in Hispanic students in comparison to enrollments in 2021 (UNM Newsroom). According to enrollment numbers, higher education in New Mexico is suddenly flourishing among historically underrepresented students with the onset of the Opportunity Scholarship, fueled in part by a boom in oil and gas.

Jonathan Juarez-Alonzo is a former undergraduate student at the University of New Mexico, and an Indigenous Two-Spirit climate activist and member of the Pueblos of Laguna and Isleta, and Chairmxn of the Board of Directors of Pueblo Action Alliance, a grassroots organization working to combat environmental racism in New Mexico. Throughout 2019, Juarez-Alonzo organized climate strikes across Albuquerque, in which thousands of students protested local and state climate policies. In 2022, Juarez-Alonzo wrote an op-ed titled, “Tuition-free college isn’t free when it’s funded by oil and gas,” which was published in an independent news organization, *Source New Mexico*, which reports on government policy through a public health and equity lens. The public comment articulates reasons Juarez-Alonzo is

“currently on an indefinite leave of absence from the University of New Mexico” (1). In compelling detail, Juarez-Alonzo names reasons for enrolling in the university as a first-generation undergraduate: “I started college eager for my future and the positive impacts an education would bring to me and my family long-term.” Then, Juarez-Alonzo writes about less-spoken, more often whispered, reasons for withdrawing from the program: “As I started paying attention to climate policy and actions, or lack thereof, on a local and state level, all my ambitions for a higher education were eclipsed.” The op-ed elaborates, “Students like myself feel our futures are being held hostage: Do we invest in ourselves and take advantage of free higher education? Or should we even be wasting these last fleeting years of our youth in a classroom when our elected leaders are leading us down a path toward total climate collapse?” Juarez-Alonzo’s questions point to a central tension in the premise of the Opportunity Scholarship, which promises to provide equal opportunity and a bright future to all residents of New Mexico. The Opportunity Scholarship is increasingly framed as a public benefit made possible through the revenues of an expanding fossil fuel industry. This narrative and material tethering raises difficult questions about the conditions under which educational opportunity is produced and the kinds of futures such policies ultimately secure. Juarez-Alonzo’s op-ed frames the choice to attend college and work toward a sustainable, ecologically and economically viable future, or not, as a decision that is lose-lose. For this student, the premise looks like a trap.

Juarez-Alonzo’s brilliant critique reveals an inflection point in the narrative architecture of higher education in New Mexico, exposing how educational opportunity is increasingly tethered to the logics of extraction that shape the region’s land and political economy. If we think about history as storytelling, we can turn to etymology, which suggests the word “history” (n.), in English (late 14c.), is a “relation of incidents,” whether true or false, and derives from the Greek *historia*, meaning “a learning or knowing by inquiry” (OED). The histories of land and its systems continually inform present circumstances, whether they circulate as accepted narratives or remain contested accounts. History may therefore emerge not only as a fixed narrative but also as a form of inquiry, or a question about how the past is told and by whom. As Aja Martinez writes in “A Case for Counterstory,” “I believe that we’ve all been telling stories all along” (1-2). The history of land use in New Mexico is one such story, negotiated and contested by communities for centuries. According to Martinez, “Some stories are elevated to the status of theory, scholarship, and literature, while, too often, minoritized perspectives are relegated to marginalized or overlooked ‘cultural rhetorics’

methods or genres.” Within this framework, the question becomes whose stories of land come to constitute the authoritative relation of incidents. In Juarez-Alonzo’s op-ed, the narrative of “tuition-free college” functions as a public-facing narrative that masks another story, one that goes back centuries. In the unfolding story of higher education in New Mexico, funding “through oil and gas” may appear as a recent narrative development, yet this story emerges from a much deeper historical conflict over land, extraction, and the futures such arrangements make possible. In the “story” of higher education in New Mexico, “funded by oil and gas,” might be the most recent rising action of an ever-unfolding conflict around whose future matters.

Juarez-Alonzo’s op-ed arrived on the heels of the announcement by New Mexico Governor Michelle Lujan Grisham that she was signing Senate Bill 140, the New Mexico Opportunity Scholarship Act, making provisions for any New Mexico state resident graduating from a New Mexico high school to attend public college in the state of New Mexico for free (“Governor Signs”). In her statement in a speech in Silver City (now published at the NM Governor’s official website), Lujan Grisham announced:

For over a quarter of a century, New Mexico has been a national leader in providing free college to its residents. A fully funded Opportunity Scholarship opens the door for every New Mexican to reach higher, strengthening our economy, our families and our communities.

The bill was presented as the first of its kind in a long line of efforts to reduce the cost of education in New Mexico, a triumph for the liberal state and its residents. And it is, in its way, a triumph. In the statement, the governor continued, “Signing this legislation sends a clear message to New Mexicans that we believe in them and the contributions they will make for their families and the future of our great state.” In the governor’s framing, students are invited to “reach higher.” A future is envisioned for “our great state.” And ultimately, a picture is painted of something better, loftier, and more secure for residents of New Mexico.

The interrogation of these narratives is as much the responsibility of faculty as it is that of students like Juarez-Alonzo, but the imperative to critically analyze this story perhaps belongs most urgently to the broad coalition of supporters of public education in New Mexico and to those invested in the promise of tuition-free higher education. Such analysis requires attention not only to policy outcomes but also to the rhetorical infrastructures through

which universities frame their commitments to students, communities, and public good. Institutional narratives about opportunity, access, and investment often function as mediating languages that translate complex political economies, such as those linking higher education funding to extractive industries, into seemingly neutral or celebratory terms. Examining these rhetorical structures allows us to see how certain stories about universities and their public missions become normalized, even when they remain disconnected from the material conditions shaping the communities they claim to serve. In addressing institutional rhetorics of community, literacy scholars Vani Kannan, Ben Kuebrich, and Yanira Rodríguez have invoked the importance of infrastructural critique in their advocacy of what they call rhetorical “unmasking,” writing:

Since ‘community work’ in academia can both be seductive and appear to scholars as the only possible avenue for social justice, we have recognized the necessity of unmasking the current infrastructure we work under and upending the logic of infrastructure-building (Kannan et al. 76–93).

In their case study at Syracuse University, Kannan et al. examine the rhetorics of the “corporate military university,” pointing out that seemingly banal terms like “the student experience” (in this case, slogans like “reach higher”) can operate as codes that embed university values in a system that is actively detached from the present and future needs of students’ (landed) communities and lived experience of systemic infrastructure (76). Corroborating this, Carmen Kynard, in “Teaching While Black: Witnessing and Countering Disciplinary Whiteness, Racial Violence, and University Race-Management,” states, “In this absence of a deliberate critique of power, we ourselves created the very possibility that progressive philosophies of education could be completely co-opted by neoliberalism. . . we may have supplied a much too-neutral language” (11). Combatting this co-optation requires more than critique at the level of language; it demands sustained pressure on the institutional infrastructures through which these narratives circulate and acquire legitimacy. Such work necessarily unfolds both within and beyond the university, as students, faculty, and community members contest the terms through which institutions narrate their commitments to equity, opportunity, and public good. As Kannan et al. note, “Pressing social justice struggles are not only located on campus, but often against campus,” reminding us that universities themselves frequently become

sites where competing visions of community responsibility and political accountability are negotiated (77). This tension may leave faculty and students feeling implicated in institutional structures whose public-facing narratives obscure their material entanglements. Yet it also signals the possibility of intervention. When these narratives are critically interrogated, when their infrastructural logics are unmasked, they reveal the contingent foundations upon which institutional legitimacy rests. In the case of tuition-free higher education in New Mexico, such scrutiny makes visible how the promise of educational opportunity is embedded within a broader political economy of extraction, compelling supporters of public education to confront not only the benefits such policies deliver but also the land-based conditions that make those benefits possible.

At the NM Governor's Office official website, the administration proposes that the New Mexico's Opportunity Scholarship, implemented by Lujan Grisham in 2020:

is the only state-funded scholarship program in the nation to include both recent high school graduates and returning adult learners; accommodate part-time students; include career training certificates, associate degrees and bachelor's degrees; and cover summer courses. In addition to covering full tuition and fees at in-state public colleges and universities, the scholarship lets students stack federal aid such as Pell Grants, local scholarships, and private scholarships so that they can use these funds to pay for books, materials, housing, food, transportation, childcare and other college costs.

Nowhere on the website does the program indicate where the funds for this program originate, and the state's reliance on revenue from oil and gas industry expansion remains largely visible only to residents who follow the industry closely or track state legislative sessions. The governor's website directs the public and prospective students to the Opportunity Scholarship information site ("Governor Signs"); the current Reach Higher New Mexico page explains eligibility requirements for the scholarship. The information sits next to a glossy photograph of Lujan Grisham in a bob haircut and silver jewelry, a juxtaposition that invites multiple readings. Some local liberal publics may interpret the incorporation of Indigenous jewelry as a familiar visual gesture within state politics, a politicized aesthetic signaling an appeal to the broad multicultural coalition that sustains public higher education in New Mexico. Others may read it as a settler claim to belonging in occupied

territory. Held side by side, these interpretations invite a movement between readings that unsettles the stability of the official narrative. Such interpretive shifts enact the kind of narrative reworking necessary for destabilizing settler stories of land and belonging. What might initially appear as a misreading of rhetorical intent becomes, instead, an attunement to the simultaneity of stories operating within the same political image.

## **OIL/SCHOOL**

The link between the success of free public higher education in New Mexico and the success of the oil and gas industry is a narrative that has taken on legislative legitimacy as state rhetoric increasingly grafts the two sectors together. In December of 2021, the New Mexico Oil and Gas Association (NMOGA) reported revenues of \$5.3 billion for 2021, an increase of \$500 million over fiscal year 2020. According to oil, gas and environmental journalist Adrian Hedden, 2021 sets a new record, “surpassing \$5.16 billion generated in FY 2019, and providing \$2.96 billion to the State’s General Fund along with \$358 million in local taxes and another \$1.95 billion state taxes and royalties.” Hedden notes that this increase is likely attributable to expanded oil and gas production in the Permian Basin in Southeastern New Mexico. These outcomes have helped position New Mexico as the second-largest oil-producing state in the United States, behind Texas and ahead of North Dakota.

At the same time, oil and gas industry advocates have pushed back against environmental regulations designed to limit emissions and ban the burning of excess gas, known as “flaring,” measures implemented in 2021 by the Oil Conservation Division. Industry advocates have also critiqued regulatory initiatives by the New Mexico Environment Department designed to limit methane and volatile compound releases that create pollution and contribute to ozone formation. In public statements responding to these regulatory efforts, industry leaders have argued that restricting oil and gas development would threaten the revenue streams that support essential public services, including education and healthcare. Hedden writes, “NMOGA President Leland Gould said the added revenue would support essential public services like education and healthcare, solidifying fossil fuel as a major driver of New Mexico’s economy.” Such claims reinforce a broader political narrative in which the fiscal stability of public institutions, among them higher education, appears increasingly dependent on the continued expansion of fossil fuel extraction in the state.

In speeches, Gould has taken pains to link the success of public higher education in New Mexico to the success of oil and gas, stating that “Historic revenue equals historic opportunity, and that is great news for teachers and students, critical first responders and healthcare workers, and each and every New Mexican across this state” (qtd. in Hedden). This ideological linkage, articulated in terms laid out by Gould and others, prompts me to use the term *oil/school* to theorize the social, activist, liberatory and pedagogical efforts that take place under its regime. The term *oil/school* foregrounds how extractive economies are made to appear as the enabling condition of public goods, producing a form of extractivist governance in which land, labor, and social infrastructure are mobilized to support settler-colonial economic projects. In *oil/school*, the “/” compares and conflates the two terms while resisting the overdetermination of a future contingency. Whether the linkage between “oil” and “school” is mobilized by industry actors and their political allies to garner support from constituencies that historically champion the latter (education and healthcare) but not the former (fossil fuel extraction) remains difficult to determine. As Jodi Byrd, Alyosha Goldstein, Jodi Melamed, and Chandan Reddy theorize in their introduction to the collection *Predatory Value: Economies of Dispossession and Disturbed Relationalities*, settler-colonial logics structure extractive regimes that continuously render land and labor available for accumulation while masking these dynamics as neutral or beneficial (1). *Oil/school* names an assemblage in which extraction economies, state fiscal policy, and public education infrastructures are rhetorically and materially intertwined in just this way. When oil and gas industry leaders themselves repeatedly make the association, the revenue flows accordingly.

Economic reliance on oil and gas, such as in water-scarce countries in the Middle East and the Persian Gulf, does not easily shift in regions facing desertification, water scarcity, and extractive economies, as Eckart Woertz observes in *Oil for Food: The Global Food Crisis and the Middle East*: “Oil and gas revenues supply the bulk of the foreign currency that finances the growing food imports of the region” (Woertz 3). Considering the 2008 global food crisis and the entanglement of food, finance, and energy in the Gulf’s political economy, Woertz further notes, “As Saudi Arabia phases out its own internal subsidized wheat production and moves away from food production at home due to water scarcity, it relies increasingly on global oil exports to maintain food security” (3). This structure, he notes, is not easily shifted. While the geopolitical and infrastructural circumstances of New Mexico differ in scale and history, the state faces analogous conditions in which dependence on extractive industries structures economic, environmental,

and social outcomes. This tethering situates students within a paradoxical economy: their opportunity to pursue education without pressing financial burden is produced through an industry that threatens ecological and social sustainability. Access to free education becomes tied to the ebb and flow of a global fossil fuels market, an economy that many students see as a threat to their survival, not only in an imagined, and endlessly delayed future, but in the present. Oil/school relies on the ways public goods are contingent upon extractive economies, thus illuminating the ways in which settler-colonial and extractive logics converge. The result is “opportunity” for some, sustained upon the structural and ecological precarity of others, if not all.

In the 1960s, propelled by the Federal Aid Highway Acts of 1938, 1944, and 1956, the Dwight D. Eisenhower system of Interstate and Defense Highway expanded Interstate-25, carving a line due north through New Mexico and Colorado. This highway extended across so-called “Front Range” cities like Longmont, Fort Collins, Lafayette, Boulder, and Broomfield, many of which dot across existing and proposed oil and gas drilling sites. In Boulder, Colorado, fracking bans and moratoriums have been proposed in the interest of protecting the influx of high-value real estate development, even as the Colorado Oil and Gas Conservation Commission works “to establish more stringent setback distances between new oil and gas development and occupied buildings” (“Land Development”). The tension in the region between real estate and oil and gas extraction exemplifies the prevailing political struggles in settler Colorado, where environmental protection, economic development, and property value are entangled. K. Wayne Yang observes that “land is a predominant concern in settler colonialism” (Yang 116), a concern articulated through the triadic social arrangements he describes: settlers accumulate wealth by shaping land, Indigenous inhabitants’ claims are extinguished, and chattel labor is kept landless (116). In this framework, land is structured by hierarchies of race, class, and legality that enable extractive accumulation. In settler economies, where environmental interests are often cited as reasons to protect an area from drilling, real estate is often an underwriter of fracking and drilling bans. In the *Longmont Observer*, a recent article highlighting the tensions between land development and oil and gas suggests that the industries are on a “collision course”: “In places like North Dakota’s Bakken oil field or Wyoming’s Powder River Basin, there is little competition between land development and drilling for oil and gas. Not so for the Niobrara shales in the Denver-Julesburg Basin” (“Land Development”). In Colorado, the overlap of real estate development and fracking zones illustrates precisely a “disturbed relationality,” wherein land that is

valuable for ecological, residential, or aesthetic reasons is simultaneously a site of industrial extraction, and policies, zoning, and infrastructure are mobilized to manage these competing claims in ways that reproduce settler wealth and dispossession. Today, horizontal drilling and fracking account for around 85% of all new wells in Colorado, most located east of the Front Range, north of Denver, where “Interstate-25 runs right through the richest deposits in Colorado. . .” (“Land Development”). Meanwhile, the population surrounding Interstate-25 is projected to double by 2040. The juxtaposition of coveted residential land and fracking zones crystallizes the way settler-environmental and extractive logics operate together, producing both environmental incentives and dispossessions, and illustrating the ongoing material and rhetorical operations of settler-colonial value production.

## **AFFILIATION**

The deadliness of border crossings is an unspoken context and concern for the oil/school. Migrants between the U.S. and Mexico navigate militarized, climate-altered desert landscapes where heat, dehydration, and surveillance produce conditions of mortal risk. Desert crossings are structured by extractive logics that render land and life precarious, made all the more dangerous under the severe climate conditions that themselves propel migrancy in ever increasing numbers. This is not the only arena in which risk structures fossil fuel extraction, however. Fracking booms generate violent environments in the border towns and rural regions where they unfold. These concerns, those of land, women, migrants, and institutions related to climate crisis and oil and gas extraction, are not discrete phenomena but interrelated formations. These threaded stories receive little attention in political debates about the oil and gas economy. The oil/school emerges within these entanglements.

“I staked my dream into the desert,” Raquel Gutiérrez writes in *Brown Neon*, a collection of essays that wrestles with what it means to inhabit a terrain shaped by the social and political history of migrancy in the Southwestern U.S. Rachel León observes, “An essay can’t listen, but [Gutiérrez’s] comes close, leaving room for questions left unanswered and realities left unlivd” (1). In the essay, “Difficult Terrains: Do Migrants Dream of Blue Barrels?” Gutiérrez reflects, “The border and the imprint of migrants’ deaths left in its hinterlands animate most experiences I have in the surrounding nature” (83). History, particularly the histories of landed violence, displacement, and survival, imprints itself on landscape producing a tension

between land as material terrain and as lived, relational and thus politicized experience. The land itself has a story, but these stories are refracted through perception, occupation and encounter; Gutiérrez, a witness and participant, has another story, coloring the sunset with open secrets. “There’s no natural encounter—passing by a mountain range silhouette at sunset—that doesn’t have the uncanny attached to it” (Gutiérrez 83). Gutiérrez’s uncanny, here, signals the affective entanglement of land, history and human presence in the borderlands, the land itself alight with the stories of many who crossed under the hot sun.

With “I staked my dream into the desert,” Gutiérrez articulates a relational approach to land, one that acknowledges the violences, pains, dreams, projections and paradoxes of claim tethered to belonging in these border states. “To stake,” as in “to stake a tent,” conveys both claim and provisionality, a metaphor of movement and rootedness, a commitment to inhabit while remaining responsive to environmental, social, and economic pressures. Land in this formulation is active and it responds, resists, and shapes human relations while simultaneously reflecting human histories. While attending to the lived experiences and violent persecutions of migrants crossing the Sonora, Gutiérrez’s writing seems to ask, aren’t we living in a threshold of uncanny relations, affectively bound by our own lived betweenness? The word “staked,” as in *staked a tent*, also implies a necessary availability to migrancy, a readiness for change and an orientation to contingency in an economic system fostering uprootedness under fossil fuels capitalism and present geopolitics. A stake can be pulled up, relocated, and hammered in again. *Yes, I can stake a claim*, perhaps like *I stake my tent for the night*.

One could describe the relationship between the oil/school and migrant precarity with the precise notion of “stakes.” What are the conceptual stakes of the oil/school? What systems does it reinforce and perpetuate? As has been made clear by scientists, fossil fuels are by far the largest contributor to global climate change, accounting for over 75% of global greenhouse gas emissions and nearly 90% of all carbon dioxide emissions (“Causes and Effects of Climate Change”). The precarities faced by migrants crossing the border, their embodied encounters with desert heat, militarization, and environmental risk, are inseparable from the broader conditions produced by fossil fuel dependency. Entangled with the broader political and ecological conditions produced by extractive energy reliance, migrants are thus inseparable from the oil/school. In another essay, titled “Difficult Terrains,” Gutiérrez observes that the effects of climate change land differently for different people: “As 115-120 degrees becomes the new normal for Southern

Arizona, indicating a climate change that may not be reversible in years to come, there is another thing one cannot deny—any slight carelessness on your part and the desert will kill you” (Gutiérrez 83). The extreme temperatures make living in the border state more deadly, even for those with access to shelter. I recall my prior hometown of Albuquerque, New Mexico, where we’d seen a reported increase of about four additional deadly heat waves per year (Segarra 2). In these regions, the oil/school bears witness to the deadliness of border crossings in militarized zones, and adjusts to increasingly heat-seared worlds.

In the essay, “Women in the Fracklands,” from *Carry: A Memoir of Survival on Stolen Land*, Toni Jensen asks, “How many close calls constitute a violence?” (2). In “Fracklands,” women in the border zones surrounding men’s camps at fracking sites end up missing, dead or disappeared. The influx of transient oil and gas workers into rural extraction regions has been linked to increases in violent crime, sex trafficking and assaults against women living near drilling sites and “man camps.” The narrator in Jensen’s “Fracklands” confronts this phenomenon, all while thinking about her own proximity to risk as she traces the routes of disappeared women. From the fracklands, Jensen writes in the second person: “You spend those thirty-eight minutes driving around the question of violence, of proximity and approximation” (2). “You” locate a feeling of eventuality in your own “close call,” an anticipation of future boundary transgressions or violent encounters. The narrator’s “proximity and approximation” is a mental stall tactic, a stage of bargaining against the inevitable violent context of her own present encounter.

Proximity to violence and assessment of its nearness is a problem for women, especially Indigenous women, in the fracklands, where the influx of transient labor coincides with heightened violence and instability. Jensen writes:

The influx of men, of workers’ bodies, into frackland towns brings an overflow of crime. In the Bakken at the height of the oil and gas boom, violent crime, for example, increased by 125 percent. North Dakota Attorney General Wayne Stenehjem called this increase in violent crime ‘disturbing,’ and cited aggravated assaults, rapes, and human trafficking as ‘chief concerns’ (6).

These “concerns,” of lands, women, and institutions, oil and gas economies and climate crisis, are related, and are now tethered to services their revenues support. Women are thus drawn into the network of consequences

generated by extractive booms, which reorganize land and social relations in environments where economic opportunity and intensified precarity emerge simultaneously. What Jensen means by the “close call” is akin to what Gutiérrez means by “the desert will kill you”: the threat always already conditions one’s existence, and as a woman, migrant, or vulnerable person, life is lived in the shadow of these structuring violences. In this sense, violence appears less as an isolated event than as a condition of inhabitation, structured through the political, ecological, and economic arrangements that govern life in extractive borderlands. One scene from the essay lingers with me long after I read, haunting me in my northerly drive. Jensen describes checking out of hotels with photo documentation. She writes:

In each place, each frackland, off each road, you wait until checkout to upload the photos of the rooms. In the year and a half of driving and talking and driving and talking, if you’ve learned nothing else, you’ve learned to wait. Because it is very, very difficult to sleep in a hotel room once you learn a woman’s gone missing from it (6).

In *Border Bodies: Racialized Sexuality, Sexual Capital, and Violence in the Nineteenth-Century Borderlands*, Bernadine Hernández examines gendered conquest through the stories of women living in the nineteenth-century U.S.-Mexico borderlands, a period marked by the arrival of U.S. settlers interacting with established landholding families. Hernández traces the intersections of race, sexuality, and violence, showing how borderlands shaped by colonial expansion, slavery, and territorial conquest produced racial and gendered hierarchies negotiated through sexual encounters. Sexual and gendered violence in the region functioned as tools of authority and territorial control, even as they were contested and resisted by those subjected to these structures. Hernández’s re-reading of borderlands history reveals sexual violence not as an aberration but as a constitutive mechanism through which colonial land regimes consolidated power. This historical framing resonates with contemporary analyses of Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women (MMIW), which situate gendered violence within the ongoing logics of settler colonialism and extractive development. Contested lands, such as those surrounding Boulder, Colorado, on the traditional territories of the Arapaho, Cheyenne, and Ute Nations, bear the marks of successive regimes of conquest, from the so-called Mexican Cession to the rapid expansion of the Front Range Urban Corridor and the rise of luxury real estate development. Beneath these transformations lies another geological and economic layer:

the Denver Basin, the oil-and-gas region whose first well was completed in 1881, making one of its fields the oldest continuously producing oil field in the United States (Higley and Cox). Any study of social life on these lands must therefore account simultaneously for the infrastructures of extraction that structure the region's political economy.

As of 2016, the National Crime Information Center reported 5,712 cases of missing American Indian and Alaska Native women and girls. The number has certainly increased since 2016, and the Center for Disease Control and Prevention has reported that murder is the third-leading cause of death among American Indian and Alaska Native women (Urban Indian Health Institute). Meanwhile, the U.S. Department of Justice's missing persons database has only reported 116 cases among thousands of known missing persons (Native Womens Wilderness). While several states in the Southwestern U.S. have implemented statewide studies on Murdered and Missing Indigenous Women (MMIW), Native Womens Wilderness, an organization based near Boulder, CO, argues that the state of Colorado has not yet begun adequately addressing this crisis. "Given that Colorado is surrounded by several states with large Native populations and has a 1% Native population density in Denver, there is a practical need for Colorado to investigate the prevalence of MMIWG2 within its borders." I note that this thread, and these efforts, take up almost no space in political debates about the oil and gas economy.

Hernández's work sutures historical and contemporary accounts of land, extraction, and gendered violence, suggesting that sexual violence is not an anomaly but as a structuring force through which colonial land regimes, historically, produced and maintained power, a legacy visible today in the extractive boomtowns and fracking regions where Indigenous and rural women face heightened risks of disappearance and assault. Jensen's return to the fracking camps of the Bakken oil fields is a reminder of the ways extractive booms reorganize social relations, producing environments where women, particularly Indigenous and rural women, experience heightened risks of disappearance, assault, and trafficking around oil and gas industry lands.

The issue, as Jensen suggests, is not the existence of sexual economies, themselves, but their emergence within the hierarchical and coercive structures of the frack camp. Such spaces are defined by gross inequities, limited protections, and unrestricted access to transient male labor forces. The disproportionate vulnerability of Indigenous women in regions shaped by extraction echoes the longer colonial histories Hernández traces, in which sexual economies were embedded within the political and economic structures of the borderlands. As Jensen writes, "Here the posture is all commerce,"

capturing how extractive economies produce social formations where labor, land, and bodies circulate within regimes of unequal power. The borderlands, shaped by colonialism, slavery, and the expansion of U.S. territory, created a landscape of racial and gender-based hierarchies, negotiated through sexual encounters. Sexual and gendered violence in the region has long been a tool of power and control used by authority, and simultaneously resisted and challenged by those subjected to these hierarchical domains.

Together, Gutiérrez, Hernández and Jensen illuminate how racialized and gendered violence in extractive regions must be understood historically and structurally, as part of the ongoing social arrangements that accompany settler expansion and resource extraction. Within these contexts, the oil/school emerges not outside these histories but within them, situated on lands whose economic and social infrastructures have long been organized through the intertwined logics of extraction, settlement, and gendered vulnerability.

Driving from one university to the other, anticipating the unfamiliar sight of the Flatiron mountains sheeting across the windows panes of office views at the University of Colorado, Boulder, I think, can we write a new story?

## **FOSSIL FUEL ED**

To produce new affiliative relations, we must claim a story of space in a language with all the lastingness and mobility of “stakes.” Pedagogical practices, whether inside or outside of the university classroom, recalling Fred Moten’s notion that “study is already going on, including when you walk into a classroom and before you think you start a class” (Harney and Moten 112), may foster an attunement to new spatial affiliations in and outside the university. K. Wayne Yang reinforces the notion that even educational practices that set out to address issues of the “environment,” or solely of “climate crisis,” without taking into consideration the wider forces of settler colonialism and its ideological products, fall short of potentially examining their structural investments and provoking a real reckoning (117). Without pedagogies and practices of storytelling that attend to praxes of affiliation, it is impossible to restructure either our materials or our vocabularies, and we fail in reordering social ways of living on land. According to Wayne Yang, “Environmental education has been largely silent on land, that is, silent on the settler colonial recasting of land into ‘environment,’ and silent on broader Indigenous understandings of land as ancestor, as sovereign, as people-places with their own politics and identities” (117–18). Denaturalizing

the university, while recalling Gutiérrez's "there's no natural encounter," only the experience of the "uncanny" in nature, means making transparent its structures of power and affiliation. This supports a more complex attunement to the oil/school's contexts. Its paradoxes may be unexpected or even arresting, and may be difficult to untangle.

In unfolding a real relationship to space that is not idealized, but is instead infrastructurally integrated and historically and personally attuned, Mishuana Goeman names, contests and counters the practice of the "abstracting of land" that occurs through nation-building under colonialism (Goeman 34). Where Kannan et al. argue that the co-opting of the word "community" by universities influenced by a corporate or military ethos furthers a sense of disjunction between universities and wider communities (77), Goeman emphasizes that the maintenance of liberal settler nation-states relies on precisely these forms of rhetorical abstraction like the co-opting of words: "community"; "reach higher"; "our future." Kannan et al. consider the inherent tension in wondering about "the problem of thinking how/whether a discipline could be accountable to a movement" (78), which may be addressed by Goeman's emphasis on resistance to rhetorical abstraction, a resistance that emerges through political and pedagogical efforts to make transparent the embeddedness of the university in colonial systems. Oil/school might thus be understood as a strategy of transparency that learns from Goeman's "storied land," a process thus invested in theoretical and material storytelling, which has the potential to dismantle our most alienating settler ideologies.

According to Goeman, "Storied land is a partial answer to the question, 'How do we uproot settler maps that drive our everyday materiality and realities?'" (170). As Gutiérrez has demonstrated, place is produced in and through narrative, and thus our spaces are constituted by the stories we tell about their relations. These narratives of place have their specific rhetorics of progress and languages of dominance. Returning to Juarez-Alonzo's critique of oil/school, students are increasingly asking, *what story are we telling about this space?* The only story to tell of the oil/school is the story that offers a sense of situatedness in lived affiliations and processes, including the very real and direct connections to settler colonial structures and extractive industries.

Fostering student leadership in storying practices is crucial. In January of 2023, the first day of the New Mexico legislative session, YUCCA (Youth United for Climate Crisis Action), an advocacy group formed of youth members from Santa Fe, Española, San Felipe Pueblo, Kiwa Pueblo, Picuris Pueblo, the Diné Nation and Las Vegas, NM, organized die-ins for

structural change in the rotunda of the New Mexico State Capitol. YUCCA has activated a coordinated set of demands that lawmakers take action to address the ongoing climate crisis and eschew “chasing short-term profits [for the oil and gas industry] at the expense of long-term climate stability.” Oil/school necessitates listening to students, allowing students, as a foundational pedagogy, to articulate the ways flexing their agency within settler colonial structures achieves their educational aims. A long lineage of Black and Indigenous student activism in higher education has demonstrated that this has always been possible.

Sandy Grande, reading Robin D. G. Kelley’s “Black Study, Black Struggle,” cites Fred Moten and Stefano Harney’s theorization of the undercommons as a framework for the rewriting of institutional stories (Grande 50). Grande understands the undercommons to foment a culture in which “students and faculty work to cleave study and struggle, where they can be *in* but not *of* the university,” demonstrating practiced, salient resistance strategies (50). Silences and refusals are powerful languages of resistance where colonial structures are produced in and through language. As Kannan et al. have demonstrated, institutions derive power from language. Students have the power to refuse, re/narrate, and de/reconstruct these narratives. In “Refusing the University,” scholar Sandy Grande notes that despite the long history of the marginalization of Black and Indigenous students in university systems, “student protest and charges of racism within the settler academy are often met with surprise and disbelief” (48). Yet the YUCCA student die-ins in New Mexico occur in direct response to statements like those by the New Mexico Oil and Gas Association, which boasted at the end of 2021 that “the only obstacle to future growth, production, and revenue [for the oil and gas industry] is policy.” Students well know that policy emerges from storytelling, with themes like “Historic revenue equals historic opportunity,” where oil and gas is said to be “great news for teachers and students” (Gould). New Mexico’s scholars, educators, writers and policymakers must practice “learning from youth resistance” (Wayne Yang 116), where students advocate for policy change: a new story.

Here’s a story. According to New Mexico’s U.S. Senator Ben Ray Luján, “Millions of Americans live within a mile of an orphaned [oil] well” (“Round the Roundhouse”). South of the Colorado state border, the same week Jonathan Juarez-Alonzo argued that universities should be honest about their impact on the environment and on the very communities they serve, U.S. President Biden’s Administration moved to approve \$25 million in federal funding for New Mexico, allocated for the clean up approximately 200

abandoned oil and gas wells “in need of plugging” in the southwest Permian Basin and northwest San Juan Basin (Hedden). According to an article announcing the grant approval, “Oil and gas wells are often left abandoned by operators who decide they are no longer financially viable, continually releasing air pollutants like methane when going unmonitored” (Hedden). As the article describes, it is in fact the well operators, in the form of privately owned companies, who are responsible for funding the cleanup of “forgotten” wells with the help of taxpayer bonds to pay for their remediation. New Mexico state officials have noted that the funding allocated for this essential process is inadequate. The Oil Conservation Division (OCD), an arm of New Mexico’s Energy, Minerals and Natural Resources Department, estimated in 2021 that there are up to 1,700 decaying wells throughout the state posing a present threat to air and water. On August 22nd, 2022, just a few days before the announcement of the Biden Administration funding allocation, the group XTO Energy, an international oil and gas company whose parent company is ExxonMobil, was fined \$1.7M for violating oil and gas wastewater disposal rules. These laws were breached in the Permian Basin, where the disposing of wastewater from drilling has been tied to earthquakes in the region (Hedden).

Here is another story. Land tells a tale of our present values, inherited ideologies, submerged narratives, and surfaced traumas. It tells the story of who we are and where we are going. As K. Wayne Yang reminds us, “. . . No land is empty. It must be made empty forcibly and ideologically” (116). Embedded in Juarez-Alonzo’s call for the university to consider the future is an invocation of the present: how land is used now matters. Constructing a story of and through land is therefore a pedagogical project, one that unfolds both within and beyond institutions of public higher education among those willing to participate in its work. Following Wayne Yang and others, this project requires tracing the colonial pathways that bring people into relation with land, acknowledging how our own positions are shaped by ongoing relations to settler colonialism. This project also demands sustained attention to the language systems through which land is narrated and made intelligible. Within oil/school, these rhetorical ideologies reinforce particular narratives of land and belonging. Attending to these dynamics begins with recognizing the materiality of language itself and the ways our own linguistic practices participate in constructing the stories we tell about land. Practices of narration attentive to place therefore become acts of institutional and cultural reorientation, assembling structures of meaning through new stories grounded in the material conditions of land.

V. Jo Hsu's notion of "homing" offers one such strategy for refusing narrative dominance by foregrounding the contradictions embedded in practices of belonging. Hsu writes that "Homing. . . regards home as the difficult, collaborative, at times contradictory practice of re-placement, reimagining, and relating across distance and difference" (Hsu 9). As a critical approach to storytelling, homing explores how queer and transgender Asian and Pacific Islander subjects narrate experiences of connection and alienation in order to reimagine ongoing conditions of marginalization. In Hsu's account, home emerges not as a fixed location but as a relational practice constituted through narrative, memory, and collective negotiation: "What family/home will stand on decades of silence and centuries of erasure?" (9). Read alongside the conditions of oil/school, this framework invites attention to the ways youth in the Southwest encounter disrupted notions of home shaped by settler colonial histories and extractive economies. Locating Hsu's questions in New Mexico, one might ask how oil/school engages with youth in the Southwest whose story of history is rescripted by dominant colonial narratives. In such contexts, dominant narratives of land continue to rescript regional histories through colonial frameworks of development and progress. Extractive policies that sustain reliance on the oil and gas industry reinforce these narratives, reproducing the relations to land that Wayne Yang's identifies as central to settler colonial formation.

Such dynamics operate not only at the level of policy but also through the rituals and symbols of everyday life. In crossing state lines from New Mexico to Colorado, I trade my "Welcome" in the Land of Enchantment for a "Welcome to Colorful Colorado" sign, which hails a congregation of selfie-stick wielding tourists. "Colorado" derives from Spanish, meaning, "colored red," a name chosen by Congress when the area became a Territory in 1861 and named for the red of Red Rock Canyon and the stones of the Garden of the Gods near Colorado Springs. Even the name signals the layered histories through which landscapes become narratively framed and politically claimed. To move across these terrains is to encounter the sedimented narratives that shape contemporary relationships to land.

In traversing the mountain to leave New Mexico, I call into relation the scholars and writers whose work has guided efforts to re-route inherited narratives of place, those who have directed attention toward alternative affiliations with land and community, and edged me toward unsettling inherited and learned ideologies of space. Such scholarship invites the deliberate unsettling of received stories and the cultivation of new narrative orientations. Reworking these narratives requires acknowledging the

institutional and cultural frameworks that have long obscured the colonial histories embedded in the landscapes we inhabit. It also requires developing narrative practices capable of addressing those omissions and re-situating present conditions within broader historical and material contexts. I uproot myself in narrative so I might resource a new story.

An accounting of land demands collective attention to the failures that have shaped dominant narratives of place and the infrastructures that sustain them. Educational institutions, including those embedded within oil/school, participate in these narrative formations. At the same time, they possess the potential to cultivate alternative modes of storytelling grounded in relational understandings of land. Scholars such as V. Jo Hsu, Mishuana Goeman, and others offer frameworks for imagining such alternatives: narrative constellations, storied land, and practices of affiliation that foreground relational accountability. Together, these approaches suggest the possibility of narrative models that move beyond inherited colonial scripts toward forms of landed integration attentive to the histories, responsibilities, and futures embedded in place.

Let's write a whole story of questions: what acknowledgments might we need to address collective failures to narrate a true story of land as the story of our present context? What programs might obliterate teaching from a place of alienation from those infrastructural realities that determine our conditions?

Here's one story: Tuition-free college isn't free when it's funded by oil and gas.

Tell me another.

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